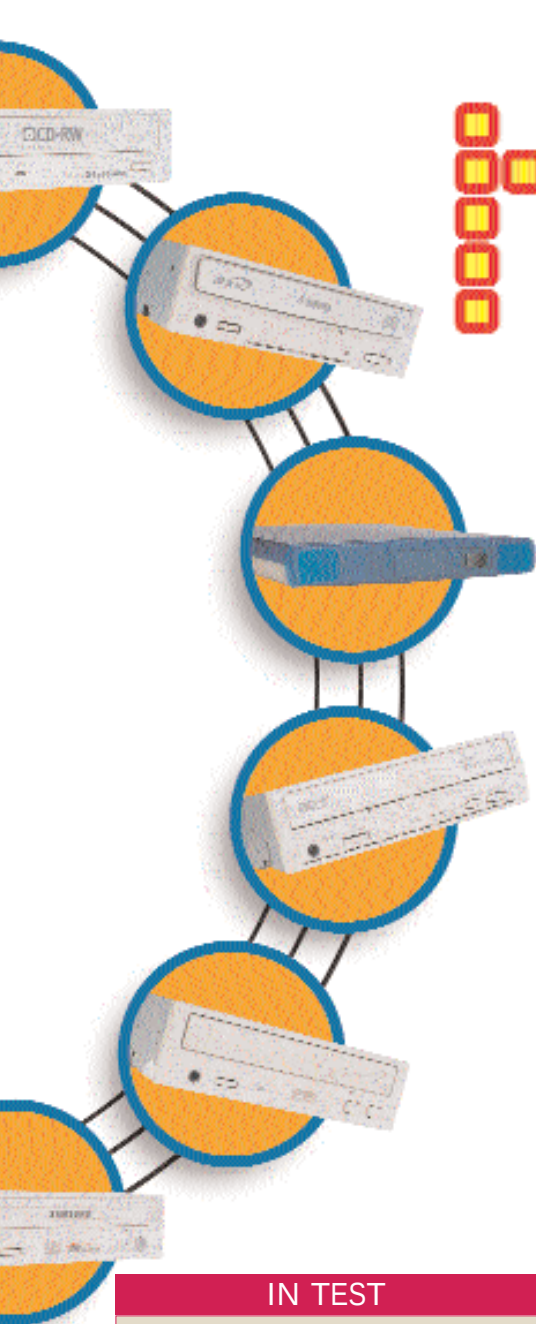




IN TEST 18 CD-WRITERS

debut and especially in the last year, the market has seen an influx of low-cost IDE writers from different manufacturers. Consequently the price of CD-RW drives has fallen to the extent that it's now well within the budget of even home users—entry level CD-RW drives cost just under Rs 6,000. Coupled with very cheap recordable media, this is truly the most cost-effective solution for freeing up that long-needed space on your hard disk. There are a plethora of speeds, interfaces and fea-

tures available that give users the choice of a very wide array of devices to suit your application and budget. For standalone applications, there are IDE and SCSI drives while for people on the move, there are external drives sporting newer and high-speed interfaces such as USB 2.0, FireWire and SCSI.

The rise of the CD writer

CD-Writers too were getting faster. Earlier the rate of increase in speeds was by 2x or 4x every year or so, while now it seems that the speed is increasing by 8x every six months! The fastest available in the world today is a 32x CD-Writer. This may seem impressive, but the trouble with CD-RW drives getting faster is that computers have a hard time keeping it supplied with data. When the computer can't supply enough data in the right amount of time, you get a buffer underrun and the result is a coaster. In the past the solution for this was to put a larger buffer on the drive and hope for the best! But this

Floppies are more expensive than some CD-Rs. A box full of CDs, numbering 25 would cost you about Rs 500. This box alone is worth 17 GB of data. All this data is stored reliably and can be retrieved as and when you want.

problem is now taken care of with the inclusion of buffer underrun protection technologies—all major manufacturers today employ this technology in some form or the other.

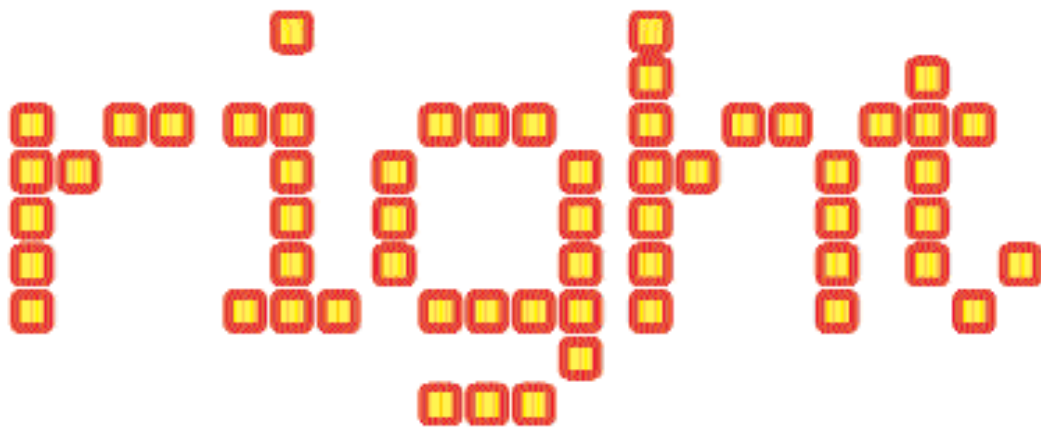
Racing for speed

This isn't F1 where even micro seconds count—a

delay of a couple of seconds wouldn't really hurt anyone but 10 to 20 seconds is something that is discernible and if you plan to write a truck load of that software you developed in your garage then every second counts!

Also, how many single large files do you think you are going to burn? Well if you plan to do a lot of video capturing, VHS to VCD conversion and the likes then writing speed is what you must consider in your purchasing decision.

The first batch of tests consisted of burning ISO images onto a CD-R. What is immediately obvious is that the time taken to burn a 700 MB CD-R is not a big deal anymore. Most CD-Writers will manage this test in less than 5 minutes. But



Make room! The right CD-Writers to burn data onto CDs so you have all the space you need on your hard disk

ISO Write Speed

